They offer comfort in the toughest of times. I reached my lowest point in the second Test against Sri Lanka in June 2014. We had a first-innings lead of 108, and my captaincy was fiercely criticized when we allowed Angelo Mathews, their captain, to accumulate 160 when the game was in the balance.

Angelo is a gutsy cricketer, with an ability to play a special innings. We were conscious of his potential to hurt us, and attempted to frustrate him when he was joined, with seven wickets down for 277, by Rangana Herath. Reasoning that the tail-ender was unlikely to score the runs required to set us a testing target, I spread the field for the first four or five balls every over, inviting the skipper to expose him.

The tactical strategy worked, to a degree, because Angelo nicked off a huge drive, which dropped an inch short of second slip. My mistake was in persisting too long with it; Herath made 48 before he was run out by Joe Root, and the Sri Lankans set us 350 to win.

I was first out, for 16, in that evening session on the fourth day. At the close we were five down, with only 57 on the board. Dear old Shane Warne was playing to the gallery by suggesting my leadership was ‘horrific’ and the worst he had ever seen. It was more of the same, sniping and toxicity, with an obvious subplot.

Thank goodness my family were with me that night. Alice had been following the scores, and drove up to Yorkshire that afternoon because she sensed I needed support. I was as close as I had ever been to quitting, drained physically and mentally. Conflicting images and messages rattled around my brain as I paced around our hotel room holding Elsie, who was barely three months old, in my arms.

I idly watched highlights from the opening day of Wimbledon as I lulled her to sleep, a comforting process with which any parent can identify. Alice urged me to stay with it, arguing that it was against my nature to give up. She was right. Stubborn to a fault, I didn’t want to be known as a quitter. It was against everything that I had been brought up to believe and express.

Trevor Bayliss, the England coach, has a saying: whatever happens, the next morning the sun rises; you get up and get on with it. My sense of calmness and renewed purpose even survived a mortifying defeat when Jimmy Anderson, who had batted without scoring for eighty-one minutes during twenty overs in which Moeen Ali completed his maiden century,